

The NCERT Booklist, Prioritized

The exact NCERTs to read, and the order to read them in, for every GS subject — so you stop guessing where to start.

How to use this: Read Tier 1 books first, cover to cover, before touching any standard reference book (Laxmikanth, Spectrum, GC Leong, etc.). Tier 2 books fill gaps once your foundation is solid. Don't collect more books than this — revising these three times beats reading forty books once.

History

TIER	CLASS	BOOK	WHY IT MATTERS
Tier 1	VI	Our Past 1	Ancient India — foundational timeline and sources
Tier 1	VII	Our Past 2	Medieval India — Delhi Sultanate to Mughals
Tier 1	VIII	Our Past 3 (Part 1 & 2)	Colonial India, 1857, socio-religious reform
Tier 1	IX	India and the Contemporary World I	World History — French Revolution, Nazism
Tier 1	X	India and the Contemporary World II	Nationalism in India & the world
Tier 1	XI	Themes in World History	World History depth for GS I Mains
Tier 1	XII	Themes in Indian History I, II, III	The single most important History NCERT set for UPSC — read this twice
Tier 2	—	Old NCERT: Ancient India (R.S. Sharma)	Deeper ancient history than the new NCERT covers
Tier 2	—	Old NCERT: Modern India (Bipan Chandra)	The standard for Modern History & freedom struggle depth

Geography

TIER	CLASS	BOOK	WHY IT MATTERS
Tier 1	VI	The Earth Our Habitat	Absolute basics — solar system, latitude/longitude
Tier 1	VII	Our Environment	Landforms, climate, natural vegetation
Tier 1	VIII	Resources and Development	Resources, agriculture, industry — India-focused
Tier 1	XI	Fundamentals of Physical Geography	The backbone of Prelims Geography — read carefully
Tier 1	XI	India: Physical Environment	Physical geography of India specifically
Tier 1	XII	Fundamentals of Human Geography	Human geography concepts tested almost every year
Tier 1	XII	India: People and Economy	Population, settlements, economic activities of India
Tier 2	—	Certificate Physical & Human Geography (G.C. Leong)	Standard reference once NCERTs are done — go here next, not before
Tier 2	—	Orient BlackSwan / Oxford School Atlas	Keep open beside every geography topic you study

Polity

TIER	CLASS	BOOK	WHY IT MATTERS
Tier 1	IX	Democratic Politics I	What democracy actually means, in plain language
Tier 1	X	Democratic Politics II	Federalism, political parties, social movements
Tier 1	XI	Indian Constitution at Work	The single best introduction to how the Constitution actually functions
Tier 1	XI	Political Theory	Rights, justice, equality — concepts GS II and Essay both draw on
Tier 1	XII	Politics in India Since Independence	Post-1947 political history — frequently tested
Tier 2	—	Indian Polity (M. Laxmikanth)	The standard reference — but only after the NCERTs above, not instead of them

Economy

TIER	CLASS	BOOK	WHY IT MATTERS
Tier 1	IX	Economics (Understanding Economic Development)	Basic concepts — poverty, food security, development
Tier 1	X	Understanding Economic Development	Sectors of the economy, money & credit, globalisation
Tier 1	XI	Indian Economic Development	Read this closely — directly maps to GS III Economy questions

Tier 1	XII	Introductory Macroeconomics	National income, money, government budget — conceptual base for Economic Survey
Tier 2	—	Indian Economy (Ramesh Singh)	Standard reference for depth once NCERT concepts are clear

Science, Environment & Culture

Tier	Class	Book	Why it matters
Tier 1	VI–X	Science (all five books)	Base concepts in physics, chemistry, biology that GS III questions assume you know
Tier 1	XII	Biology — Ecology & Environment chapters	The most exam-relevant environment content in any NCERT
Tier 2	XI	An Introduction to Indian Art	Covers Art & Culture — a small but easy-marks section
Tier 2	—	Nitin Singhania — Indian Art & Culture	Standard reference for Art & Culture depth